looked a bit staggered by the apparition'.[3] It dawned on Rahmud how time had distanced him not only from Mini, but also from his daughter in Afghanistan, who must now be of marriageable age, and with whom he would have to make friends afresh.

Reflecting the depth of India's emotional connect with and imagination of Afghanistan and its people, Tagore's short story, the Kabuliwallah, has decisively influenced the way many in India view Afghans, i.e. aggressive but righteous, united against foreign occupation but wrought with familial and tribal differences, martial and possessive but also softhearted. This cultural connect is highlighted at the end of Tagore's classic when Rahmud meets him on Mini's wedding day and shows the imprint of his daughter's small palm on a piece of cloth that he took as a memory when leaving Kabul for Calcutta eight years ago. 'Tears came to my eyes. I forgot that he was a poor Cabuli fruit-seller, while I was —but no, what was I more than he? He also was a father', wrote Tagore. Afghanistan itself is pictured as a romantic place with its 'mountains, the glens, and the forests of his distant home, with his cottage in its setting, and the free and independent life of distant wilds'.[4] Despite its social and political plurality, it is these romantic notions of faraway vistas inhabited by the fiercely independent 'Pathans' that marks India's imagination of Afghanistan.

Such cultural links have influenced India's political discourse towards Afghanistan for decades. Indian President Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed stated in 1975: 'generations ago, large numbers of Afghans made India their home and have become part of its people. They have enriched our own culture. Our great poet Rabindranath Tagore in his famous story of the "Kabuliwala" painted an unforgettable image of the robust character and the affection and love of an Afghan living in India.'[5] More recently, M. K. Narayanan, a 1955 batch Indian Police Services (IPS) officer hailing from the southern state of Kerala who first became the Director of Intelligence Bureau (1987–90), Chairman of Joint Intelligence Committee (1987–92), and went on to shaping India's foreign and security policy as a powerful National Security Advisor (NSA) from 2005 to 2010, asserts that the Kabuliwallah connection was 'fundamental' in shaping India's approach towards Afghanistan in the post-2001 scenario: